Case Study: Nashville SC Supplemental Match Prep

Conrad Lee

Overview

- Case study data scouting report for Nashville SC with new insights intended to supplement typical match preparation
- Findings are from StatsBomb 2025 MLS summary statistics and event data for the following five matches:

@ CIN
2-1 (L)
9/13/25

@ ORL
3-2 (L)
9/20/25

v. HOU
3-1 (W)
9/28/25

@ MTL
1-1 (D)
10/4/25

v. MIA
2-5 (L)
10/18/25

Nashville SC Depth Chart (4-2-2-2)

ST
SURRIDGE
Bunbury
Sipic

ST
MUKHTAR
Shaffelburg

AM
MUYL
Boyd
Perez
Pacius*

AM
TAGSETH
Shaffelburg
Qasem

CM
YAZBEK
Tagseth
Corcoran

CM
BRUGMAN
Acosta
Jones

LB
LOVITZ
Washington

LCB
MAHER
Palacios

RCB
ZIMMERMAN
Bauer
Applewhite

RB
NAJAR
Gaines

GK
WILLIS
Schwake
Valdez

Part 1: Defending Nashville

Who is effective for Nashville in the build, and how can we stop them?

Top Players by Line-Breaking Passes per 90 Minutes, Last 5 Games

Player	Line-Breaking Passes	Line-Breaking Passes / 90
Gastón Brugman	57	17.2
Andy Najar	54	14.0
Walker Zimmerman	29	8.4
Daniel Lovitz	45	8.2
Josh Bauer	16	7.2
Jeisson Palacios	13	6.5
Edvard Tagseth	24	6.1
Jack Maher	33	5.9

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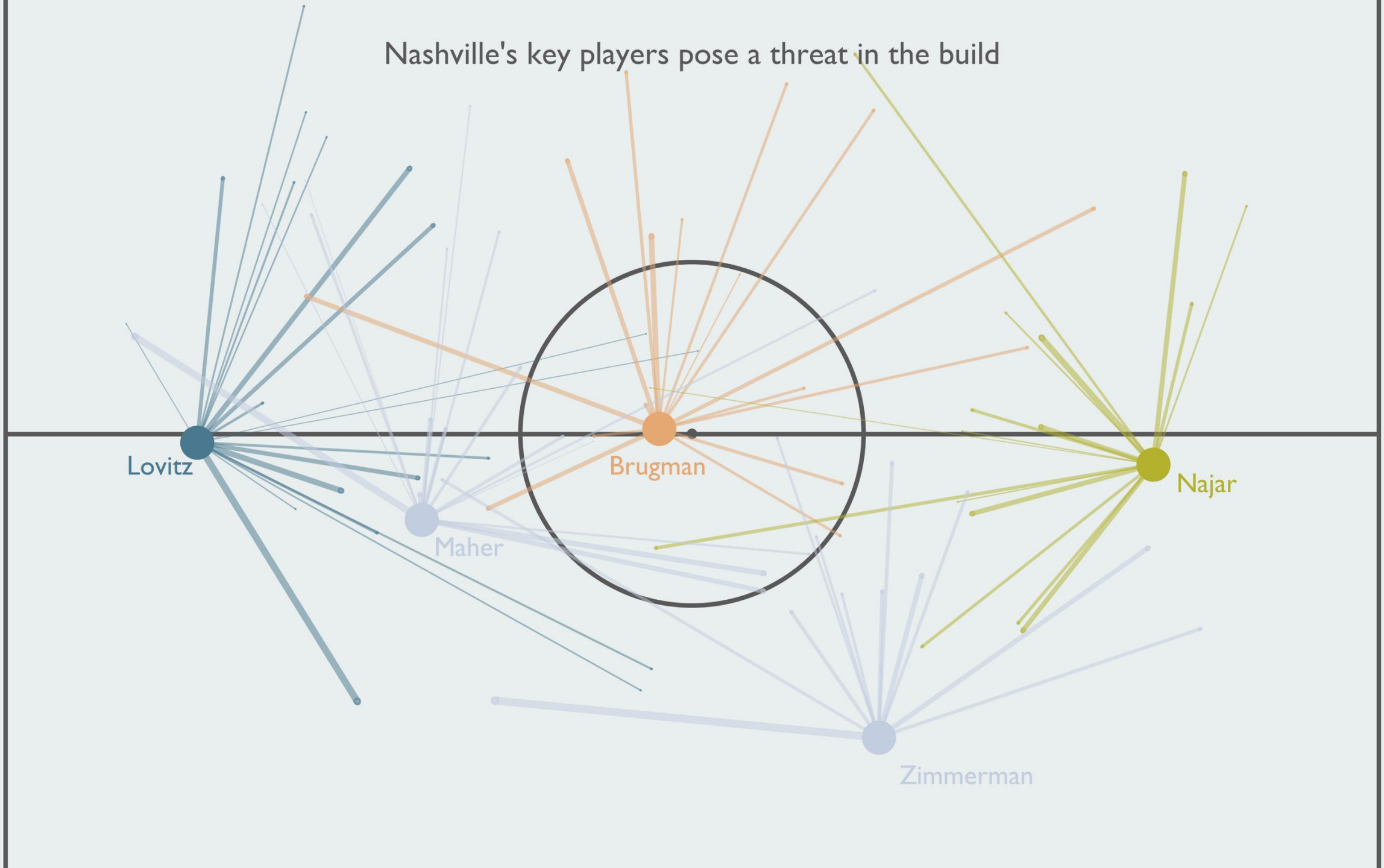
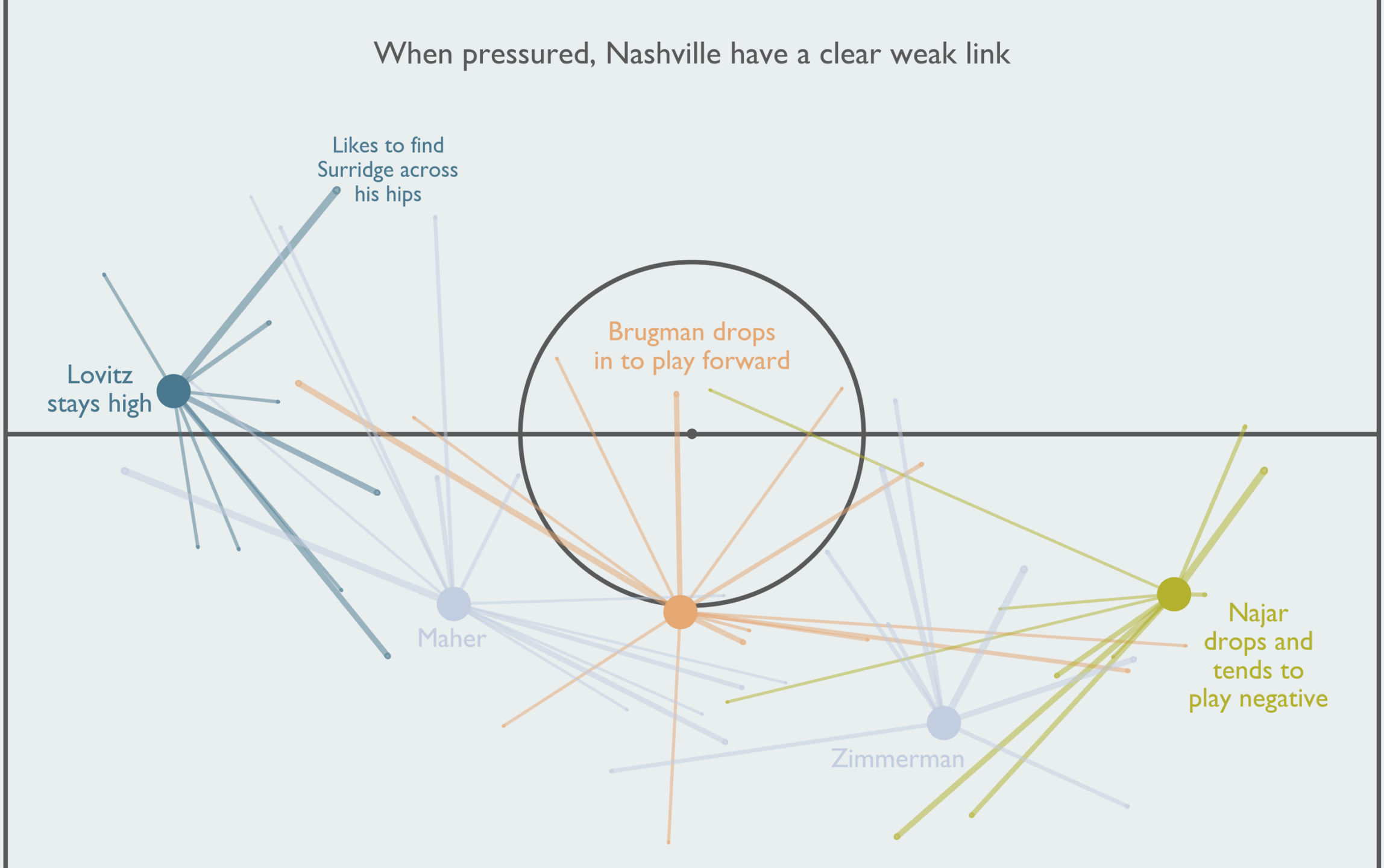
Nashville's key players pose a threat in the build



When pressured, Nashville have a clear weak link



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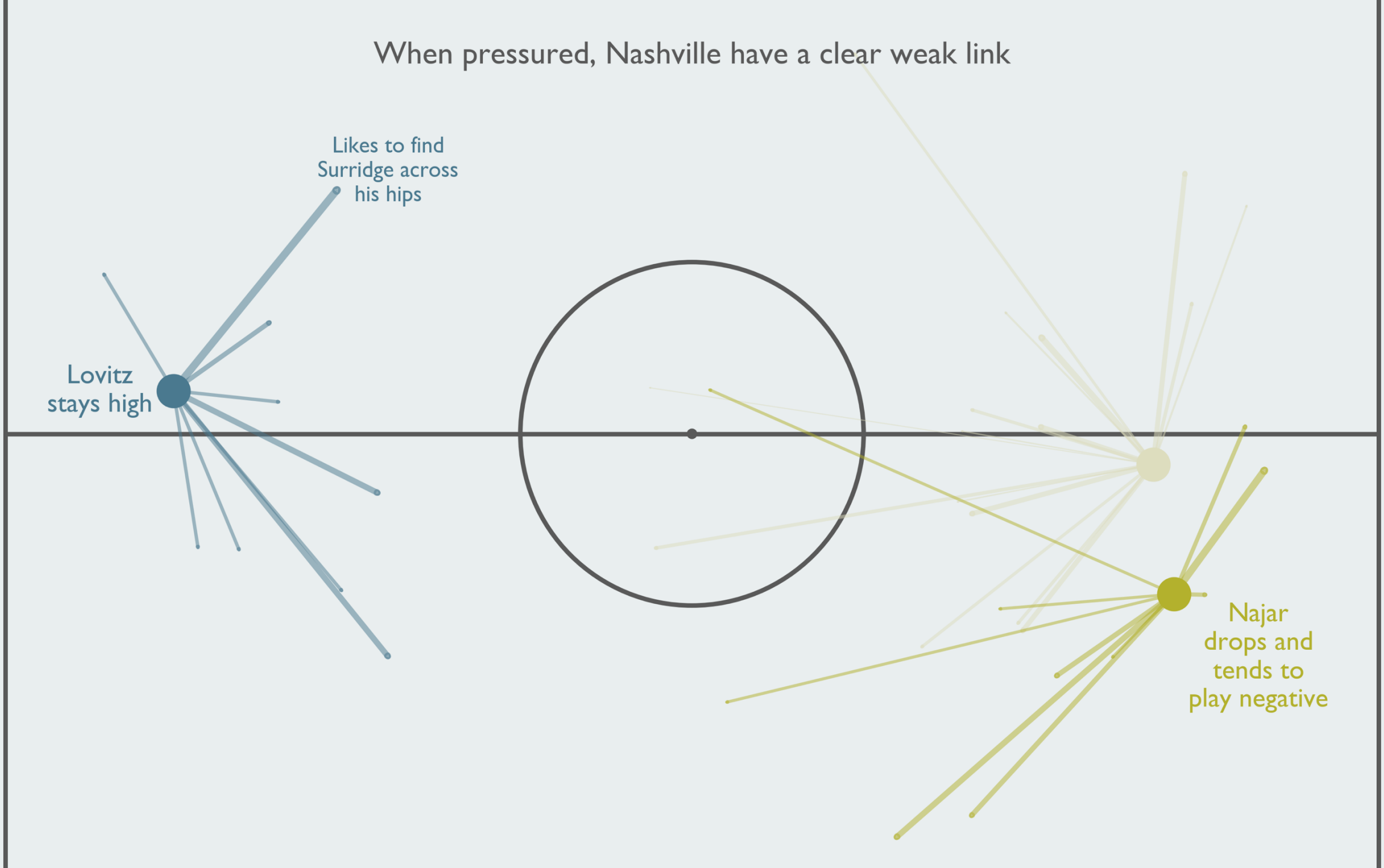


Takeaways

- Insight: Brugman will play forward and break lines under pressure, but Najar won't
- <u>Focus</u>: Denying entry to Brugman/midfield, applying good pressure to Najar
  - *Potentially shape press towards Najar*
    - Counterintuitive? Validate with video

Part 2: Attacking Nashville

Nashville SC Counterpressure Statistics, 2025 MLS Season

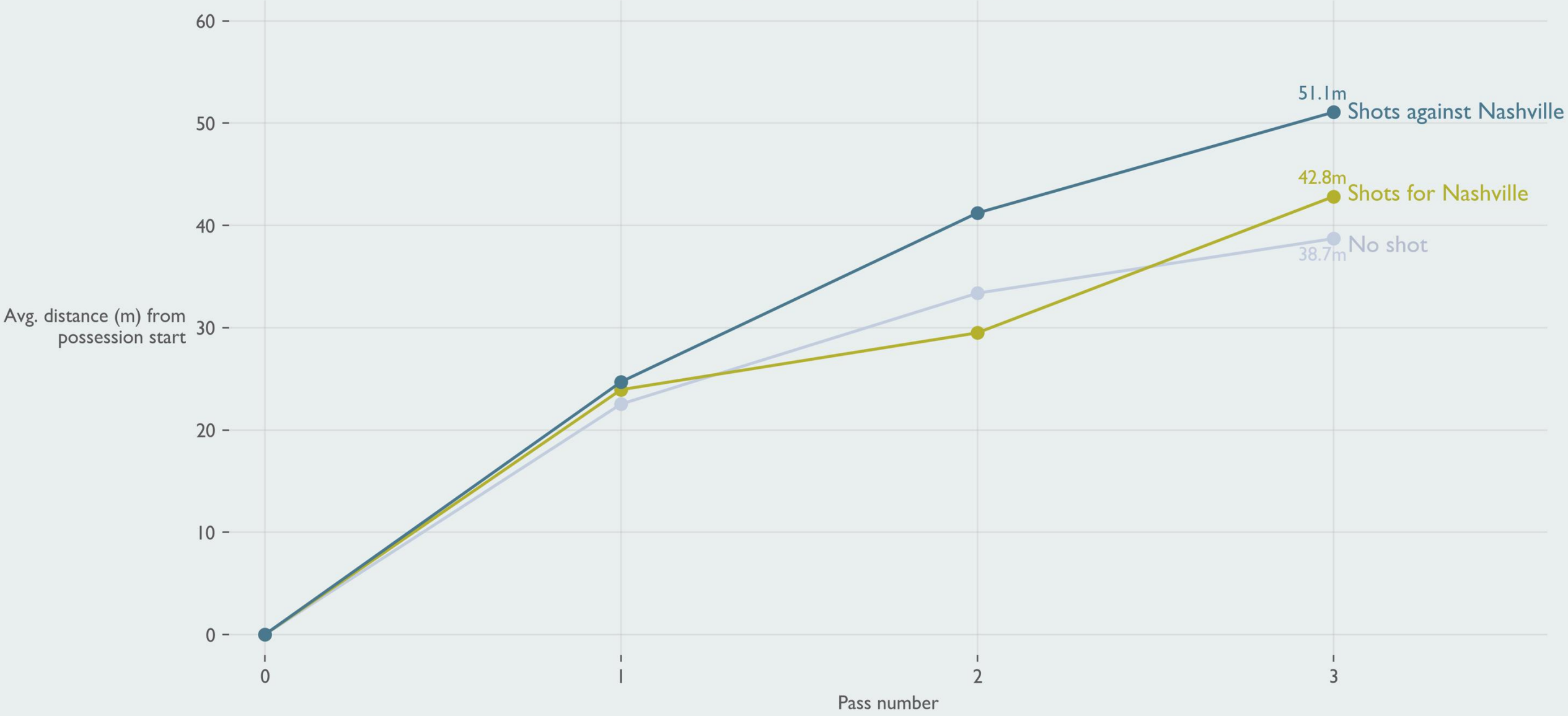
Metric	Amount (per 90)	MLS Rank
Counterpressures	35.1	10
Counterpressure Regains	5.2	26

Nashville counterpressures a lot, but it doesn’t lead to regains.

What’s happening here?

What's happening here *in the first three passes?*

Successful possessions chains (starting own half) against Nashville tend to begin by moving the ball substantially farther



Why?

ST
SURRIDGE
Bunbury
Sipic

ST
MUKHTAR
Shaffelburg

AM
MUYL
Boyd
Perez
Pacius*

AM
TAGSETH
Shaffelburg
Qasem

CM
YAZBEK
Tagseth
Corcoran

CM
BRUGMAN
Acosta
Jones

LB
LOVITZ
Washington

LCB
MAHER
Palacios

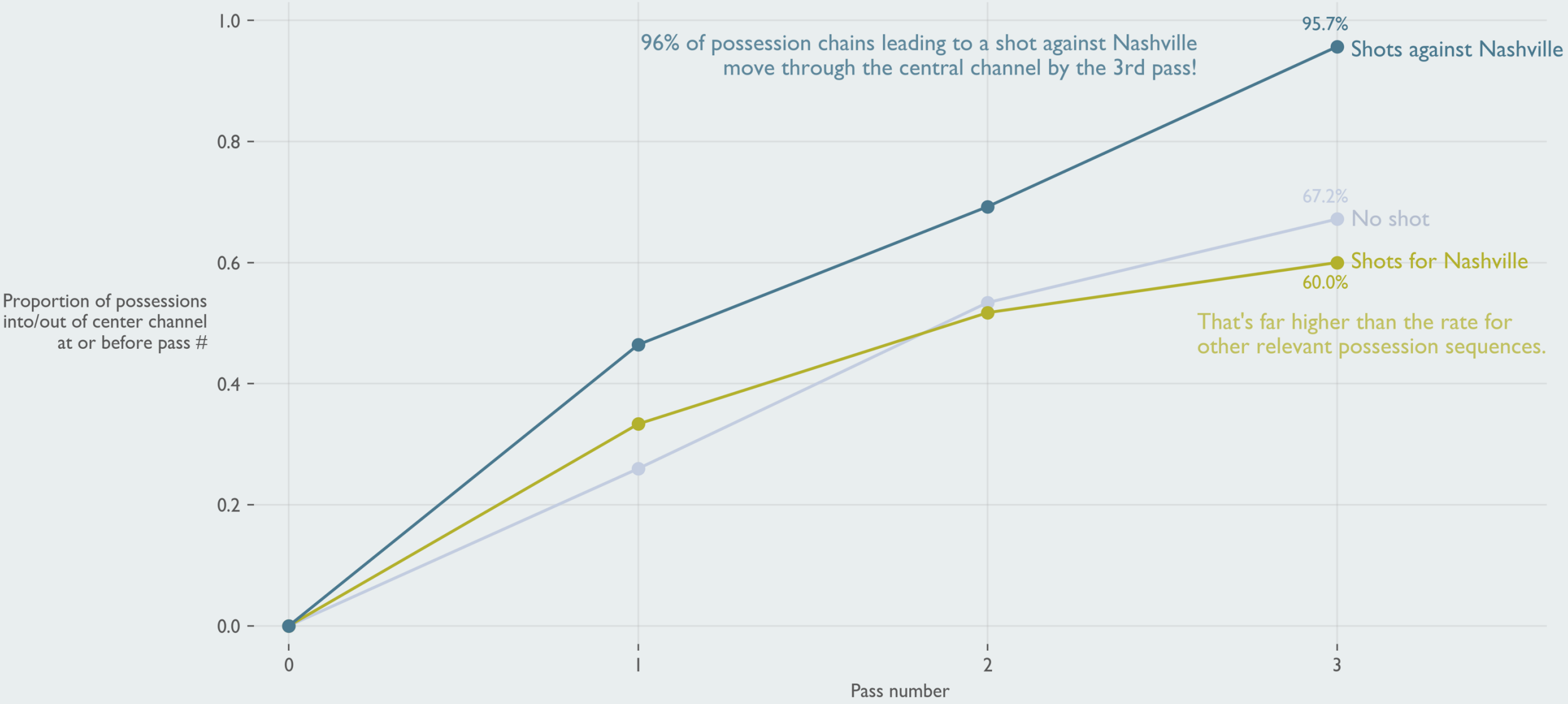
RCB
ZIMMERMAN
Bauer
Applewhite

RB
NAJAR
Gaines

GK
WILLIS
Schwake
Valdez

Notice Nashville's narrow CMs (Yazbek, Brugman) when dispossessed.

Successful possessions chains (starting own half) against Nashville tend to begin with a quick switch through the center channel



Takeaways

- <u>Insight</u>: Nashville concedes far more chances when teams *switch the field quickly* after winning the ball back
- <u>Focus</u>: Bypassing the counter-press in attacking transition by switching play
  - Can overload in midfield
    - Exploit the space wide of CMs
  - Training: Functional rondos, ex.
  - *Potentially play more direct at times*

Part 3: Managing Nashville

Orlando **3 - 2** **Nashville**

Finished

Duncan McGuire 90' +5
Martín Ojeda 32', 30'

Jacob Shaffelburg 51'
Hany Mukhtar 45' +1

21/09/2025 • 01:30 MLS Inter&Co Stadium

Nashville **2 - 5** **Inter Miami**

Finished

Jacob Shaffelburg 45' +6
Sam Surridge 43'

Telasco Segovia 90' +1
Lionel Messi 81', 63' (Pen.), 34'
Baltasar Rodriguez 67'

19/10/2025 • 00:00 MLS Geodis Park

Montréal **1 - 1** **Nashville**

Finished

Dante Sealy 9'

Sam Surridge 81'

04/10/2025 • 20:30 MLS Saputo Stadium

Cincinnati **2 - 1** **Nashville**

Finished

Evander 90' +8
Brenner 73'

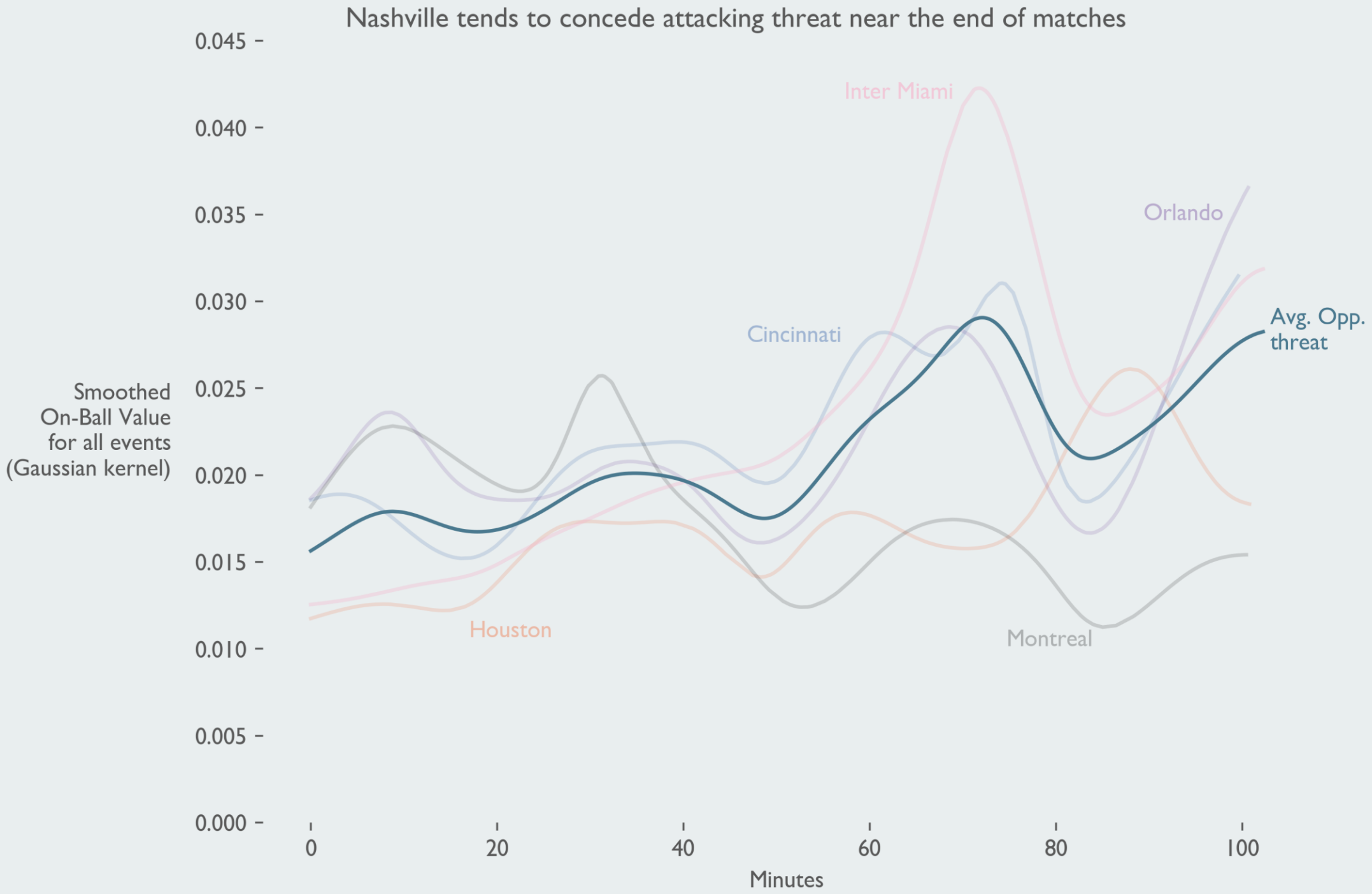
Sam Surridge 84'

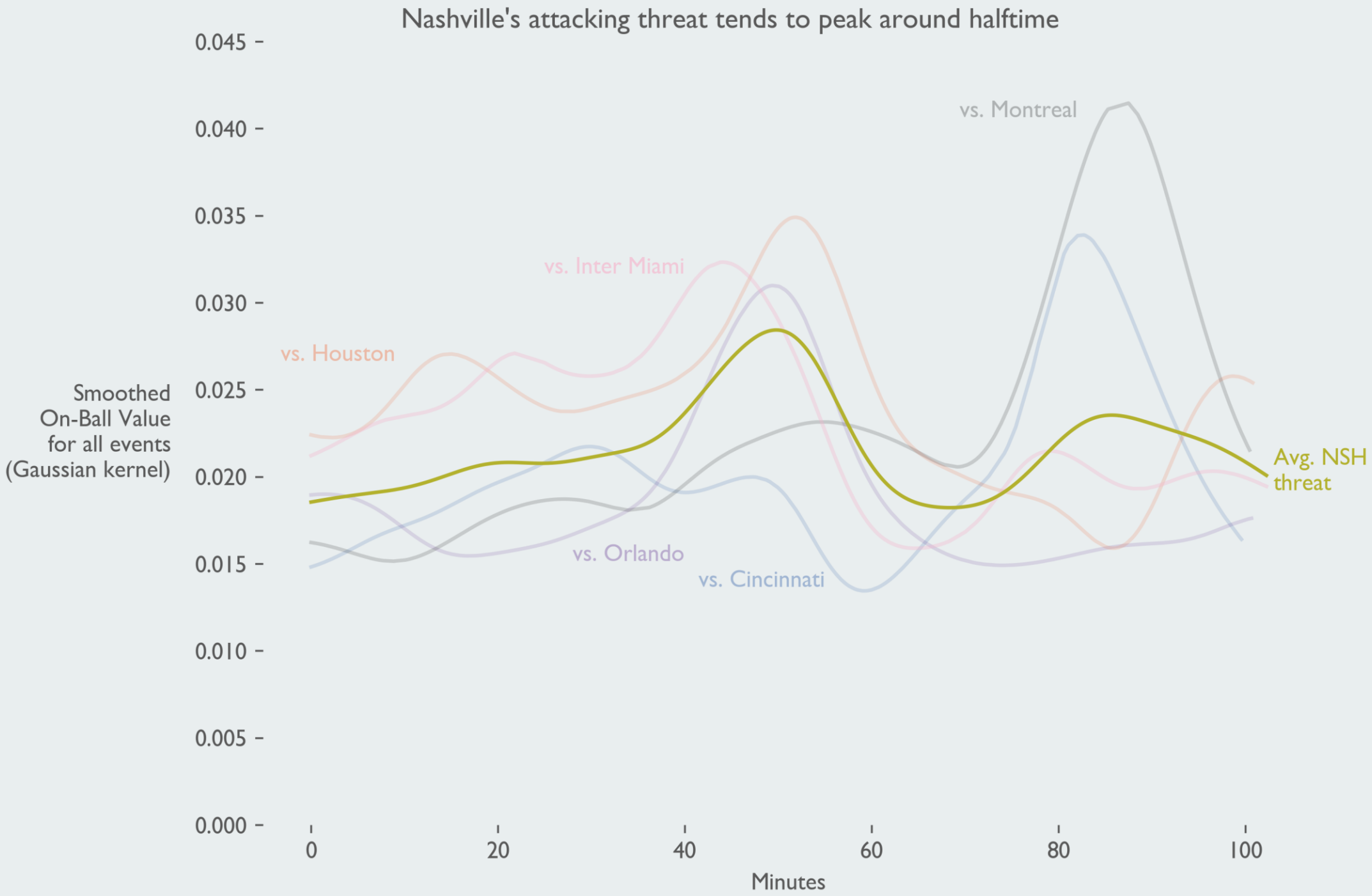
14/09/2025 • 01:30 MLS TQL Stadium

Late goals: coincidence or pattern?

On-Ball Value (OBV)

"...assigns a value to each action a player takes in line with the positive or negative impact it has on the probability of their team scoring..." -StatsBomb


Nashville tends to concede attacking threat near the end of matches
Smoothed On-Ball Value for all events (Gaussian kernel)
0.045
0.040
0.035
0.030
0.025
0.020
0.015
0.010
0.005
0.000
0
20
40
60
80
100
Minutes
Inter Miami
Orlando
Cincinnati
Avg. Opp. threat
Houston
Montreal


Nashville's attacking threat tends to peak around halftime
Smoothed On-Ball Value for all events (Gaussian kernel)
0.045
0.040
0.035
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0.025
0.020
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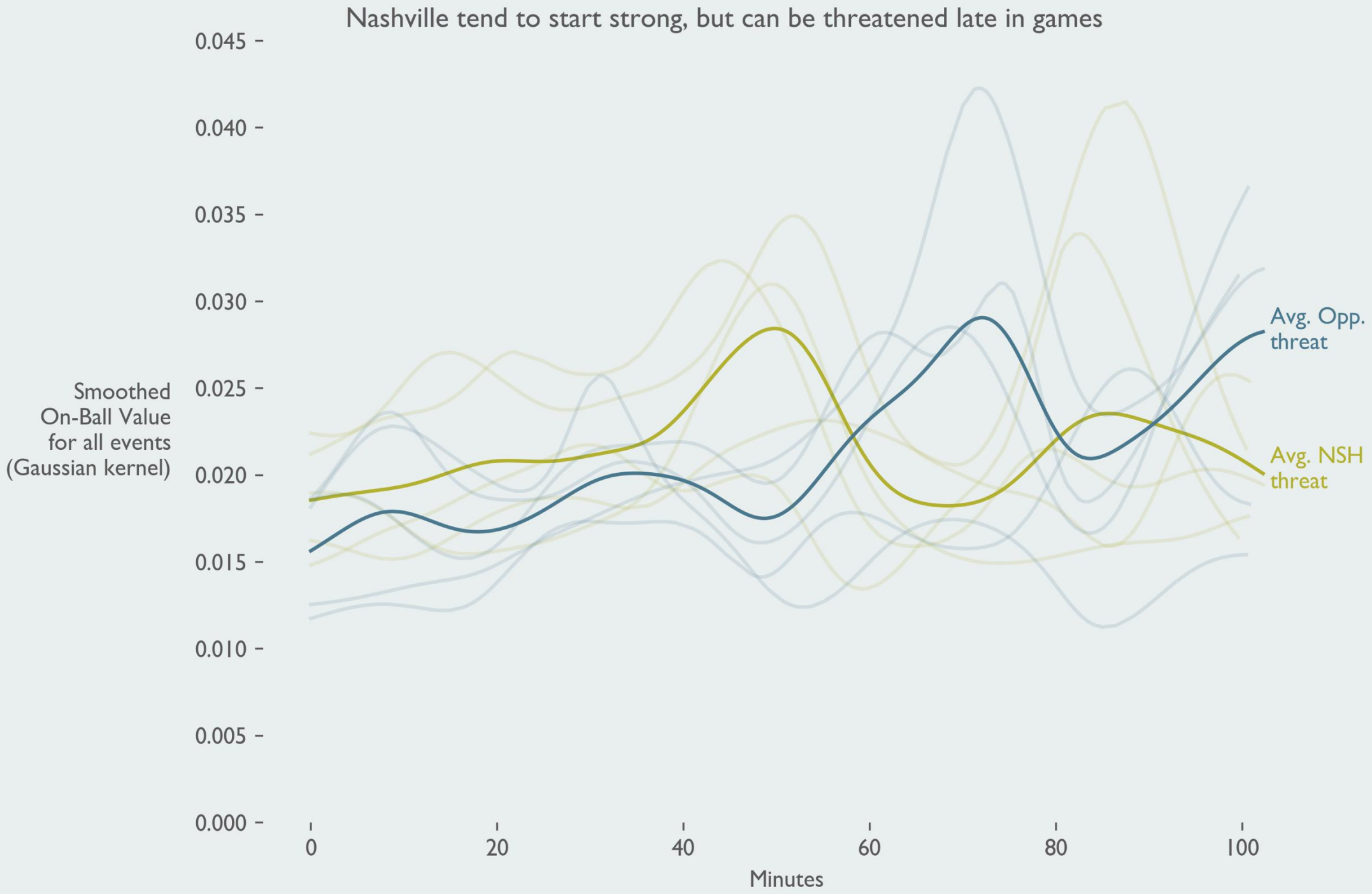
0.005
0.000
0
20
40
60
80
100
Minutes
vs. Montreal
vs. Inter Miami
vs. Houston
vs. Orlando
vs. Cincinnati
Avg. NSH threat


Nashville tend to start strong, but can be threatened late in games
Smoothed On-Ball Value for all events (Gaussian kernel)
0.045
0.040
0.035
0.030
0.025
0.020
0.015
0.010
0.005
0.000
0
20
40
60
80
100
Minutes
Avg. Opp. threat
Avg. NSH threat

Takeaways

- <u>Insight:</u> Nashville's average threat tends to peak around halftime, while opponents tend to threaten at the end of matches
- <u>Focus:</u>
  - Prepare for Nashville momentum during/ending the first half
  - Be ready to capitalize on chances at the end of the game
    - *Plan substitutions accordingly*

Summary

- Insight #1: Brugman will play forward and break lines under pressure, but Najar won't
- Insight #2: Nashville concedes more chances when teams switch the field quickly after winning the ball back
- Insight #3: Nashville's average threat tends to peak around halftime, while opponents tend to threaten at the end of matches

Rebuttals/Concessions

- Limited sample size (5 games)
  - Robustness, lack of comparison data
- Vs. Dynamo: HOU red card in 9’
- Insights could be validated with more detailed match video
  - Reliance on free public video sources for scope of project (YouTube)